

come high", *rgen* "other", *sgil* "thought", *sde:-* "to tear off". There is no reason to believe that the Xiong-nu language could not undergo the same kind of phonological development.

c) Existence of initial and intervocalic *t, *d, *k, *g, and lack of *th, *kh is also given as evidence against Altaic origin (Pulleyblank 1962: 242). While this picture surely contradicts current Proto-Altaic reconstruction (Starostin 1991), the same distribution is found in Mongolic and Tungusic.

d) As Pulleyblank noted himself, a peculiar distribution of initial *b- and medial *-p-, in Xiong-nu but not vice versa is found in both Old Turkic and Mongolian as well (1962: 242), therefore, this phonological peculiarity of the Xiong-nu language cannot be really used against its Altaic affiliation.

e) Initial *n-, as Pulleyblank notes does not exist in Turkic, but is widely present in Mongolian (1962: 242), and, I should add, in all other Altaic languages, too.

Thus, I do not find to be valid any of Pulleyblank's phonological arguments against Altaic affiliation of the Xiong-nu language. It is necessary to add, from the methodological point of view, that even if they were valid, and Xiong-nu did look very un-Altaic, it still could not constitute "proof" of its un-Altaic origins, as any argument based on phonological similarity is essentially an argument based on typology, that can be very misleading in the case of genetic affiliation. At the same time, the fact that all Xiong-nu phonological features listed by Pulleyblank, can be found in other Altaic languages, cannot constitute any evidence in favor of its Altaic origins. For this evidence, we must look elsewhere.

Besides the phonological arguments, discussed above, Pulleyblank proposed a number of lexical comparisons connecting Xiong-nu with Yeniseian. It is necessary to note that the majority of glosses found in Chinese sources represent either titles or personal names, which are practically useless in determining the genetic affiliation of a language, although it might be tempting to do so. Pulleyblank did not quite avoid this temptation, and among the words he discusses there are some Xiong-nu titles. I will not evaluate them here, as I believe that this kind of evidence is not admissible. Nor will I deal with several names for milk products, that Pulleyblank also uses, except for the word "milk" itself, as they obviously constitute cultural vocabulary, that can be easily